Julija Vaitonytė

The Hague, The Netherlands

j.vaitonyte@tilburguniversity.edu | julvai@faculty.ism.lt

SUMMARY

I have a background in cognitive science, data science, and human-computer interaction. Previously I worked on an interdisciplinary R&D project where we developed several embodied virtual agents for healthcare communication. I also conducted my doctoral research on this project, focusing on studying how humans perceive virtual agents drawing on computational modeling and experimental approaches from behavioral science and neuroscience. In 2021, I co-founded "AI Forward Forum", a platform that promotes knowledge sharing on AI through online and onsite events by bringing together researchers, industry professionals, and artists. After completing my Ph.D., I continue conducting research and teaching activities at Tilburg University. As of December 2025, I am also affiliated with ISM University of Management and Economics.

APPOINTMENTS

Tilburg University, Department of Computational Cognitive Science — December 2023–current
(Tilburg, The Netherlands)
Lecturer

Tilburg University, Department of Cognitive Science and Artificial Intelligence — December 2018–April 2023
(Tilburg, The Netherlands)
Doctoral Researcher on the "ViBE" (Virtual Humans in the Brabant Economy) project

Radboud University, Centre for Language Studies — October 2017–November 2018
(Nijmegen, The Netherlands)
Research Assistant

University of Cambridge, Department of Applied and Theoretical Linguistics — June 2017–September 2017
(Cambridge, UK)
Research Trainee

Max Planck Institute for Psycholinguistics — December 2016–May 2017
(Nijmegen, The Netherlands)
Research Trainee

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Tilburg University — defended 12 January 2024
Dissertation: "The Face Puzzle: Decoding Human Perception of Digital Agents"
Advised by Prof. dr. Max M. Louwerse and dr. Maryam Alimardani

Research Master's in Psycholinguistics (Cum Laude), Radboud University — 2016–2018
Thesis: "Gaze Allocation during Gestural Enhancement of Degraded Speech in Native and Non-native Listeners"

Bachelor's in Linguistics (Thesis grade: 10), Vilnius University — 2011–2015

RESEARCH GRANTS

- Postdoctoral fellowship | The Research Council of Lithuania (€117,529)
  Project: "Assessing the Social Influence of Large Language Models on Human Users: A Psychometric and Experimental Approach"
  Duration: December 2025–November 2027

- Co-applicant | Digital Sciences for Society grant from Tilburg University (€17,514)
  Project: "NERVE: Non-invasive Extraction of Respiratory and Vascular Estimates from RGB videos"
  Duration: September 2025–December 2026

AWARDS

- 2020. Co-recipient of the Science Communication Award and €10,000 Prize from the Dutch Research Council (NWO) for "Donders Wonders" blog
- Erasmus+ Travel Grants in 2013, 2015, and 2017

COURSES TAUGHT

- Tilburg University
  - Introduction to Cognitive Science
  - Analysis of Customer Data
  - Research Workshop: CSAI
  - Master thesis/Data Science in Action
  - Thesis Proposal

DEVELOPMENT OF STUDENTS

- Supervision of 7 Bachelor's theses, 18 Master's theses, and two internship students

INVITED TALKS AND SPEAKING

- 2024. *Invited talk*, Neuro-Innovation Group, University of Eastern Finland, Business School, Faculty of Social Sciences and Business Studies (online). Topic: "Building Meaningful Connections in Academia and Beyond"
- 2023. *Speaker*, Revolution Conference – Event Organizers Summit, Lithuania. Topic: "AI for Events: Is the Future Already Here?"
- 2023. *Invited talk*, Brownbag seminar Psychology of AI lab, Rotterdam School of Management, Erasmus University, The Netherlands. Topic: "Designing and Building Artificial Entities for Intuitive Communication in Human-facing Roles"
- 2022. *Conference presentation*, Doctoral Consortium, International Conference on Intelligent Virtual Agents (IVA 2022), Portugal. Topic: "How Do We Perceive High-quality Photorealistic Virtual Agents?"
- 2021. *Invited talk*, TAISIG talks, Tilburg University (online). Topic: "Citizen Science for AI with the AI Forward Forum initiative"
- 2020. *Speaker*, Wetenschap in de Maak (Science in the making), Tilburg University, The Netherlands. Topic: "What Can We Learn from Building a Synthetic Human?"
- 2019. *Conference presentation*, International Conference on Intelligent Virtual Agents (IVA 2019), France. Topic: "Generating Facial Expression Data: Computational and Experimental Evidence"

SERVICE AND EVENT ORGANIZATION

- 2026. Workshop at IVA 2026 “Persuasion in Conversational Agents: Research Agendas, Tools, and Frameworks” (Co-organizer)
- 2024. ECML PKDD 2024 (Chair of Social Media and Web)
- 2024. Workshop at IVA 2024 “Academia Meets Industry in Socially Interactive Agent Applications” (Co-organizer)
- 2023. The Art and AI Hackathon at Tilburg University (Co-organizer)

PEER REVIEW

- IEEE Transactions on Neural Systems and Rehabilitation Engineering

SCIENCE COMMUNICATION AND OUTREACH

- “Minties eksperimentai” (Lithuanian radio program)
- “Mokslo sriuba” (Lithuanian TV program)
- “Skaitmeniniai horizontai” (Lithuanian radio program)
- “Mokslo talentai” (Lithuanian radio program)
- “Paraštės” (Lithuanian radio program)

REFERENCES

Prof. dr. Max M. Louwerse
Tilburg University
Email: m.m.louwerse@tilburguniversity.edu

Dr. Maryam Alimardani
Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam
Email: m.alimardani@vu.nl

Prof. dr. Vita Akstinaitė
ISM University of Management and Economics
Email: vita.akstinaite@ism.lt